

Holiness

Good morning, my name is Sophia and I will be sharing a devotional on Holiness.

I first want to share from the Word, from Exodus 3:1-6:

Now Moses was keeping the flock of his father-in-law, Jethro, the priest of Midian, and he led his flock to the west side of the wilderness and came to Horeb, the mountain of God. And the angel of the LORD appeared to him in a flame of fire out of the midst of a bush. He looked, and behold, the bush was burning, yet it was not consumed. And Moses said, "I will turn aside to see this great sight, why the bush is not burned." When the LORD saw that he turned aside to see, God called to him out of the bush, "Moses, Moses!" And he said, "Here I am." Then he said, "Do not come near; take your sandals off your feet, for the place on which you are standing is holy ground." And he said, "I am the God of your father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob." And Moses hid his face, for he was afraid to look at God.

In this passage, God tells Moses to take off his sandals because he is standing on holy ground, in God's presence. What is holiness? God's holiness means that he is "other" and set apart. He is completely perfect and pure, he is without sin and transcends the ways of man, for his ways are higher and his thoughts are higher.

The angel of the Lord appears to Moses in a burning bush. When he sees this, he is in complete awe—later he writes the following after this experience: "Who among the gods is like you, O LORD? Who is like you—majestic in holiness, awesome in glory, working wonders?" Fire is majestic and powerful, and when it is near something, that thing is never the same. When it touches metal, fire purifies and refines it. God then tells Moses who He is by saying "I am the God of your father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob." It is this word that Moses needed, to know that the most powerful God of his father and ancestors was with him.

In the same way that Moses encountered God's holiness as a burning bush, I believe that when we encounter him, he refines us with His Refiner's fire. In the same way that God spoke over Moses, we can experience him working in us through his Word that is so powerful, alive, and sharp. When we really encounter him, we are compelled to live a life of obedience and holiness and we are never the same, continuously transforming. When we equate living a holy life to just going to church every week, going to Christian concerts or even serving our community, this truly dilutes the holiness of God and the life we are called into. Our lives are not meant to be stagnant and about going through the motions, but we can live a life where we experience God working in our sin

struggles, where we truly experience the freedom that He has given us and we realize the victory we have over sin.

I have experienced more recently the power of the Refiner's fire, one year ago. For most of my 20's, I struggled with stonewalling the people closest to me. For those of you who do not know what stonewalling is, it is giving people the silent treatment when I am upset or unhappy, sometimes for as long as a couple of days. This led to several broken relationships, both romantic and platonic. I used to think that even when searching for a future husband, I would have to settle for someone who "could handle me". It pained me to see how my actions would hurt the people I loved the most, and when I lost my best friend, I felt I deserved it. Therapy taught me that this was because of how my mom treated me. As young as 6, I remember never knowing on a given day whether she would be warm or shut me out completely for something I did not do. This was not her fault, because she had experienced her own form of abandonment in her childhood. This became the only version of love I knew. I wondered if this was too deeply rooted for me to ever grow out of, as it felt like part of my personality or who I am. I felt an increasing dread of the type of friend, sister, wife, and someday mother I would be. I reached a breaking point where this fear was much greater than my desire to seem like a "good Christian." It was at that time that I reached out to Esther, and shared with a small accountability group. This was the first group where I felt received with so much love and this gave me the courage to want to fight the sin in my heart. I then approached Jess and Esther for inner healing. During our sessions, I told her that as a 7-year old kid, when my mom would grow cold, I would tell myself that it was alright that my mom didn't love me, because I didn't love her either. In her deliverance prayer, she named the spirit that was bothering me—it was the spirit of lies, specifically the lie that I wasn't worthy to be loved, and she prayed a prayer to cast it out. In the following days, I did what she asked me to, which was to remind myself that I am a beloved child of God each morning when I woke up. I now had the language to fight in my prayers, I would rebuke the spirit of lies and would continuously pray for a deeper understanding of God's love for me. When I was tempted to stonewall someone, instead of telling myself not to, I reminded myself of God's unfailing love. When I felt discouraged and the lies would return, I would say—No weapon formed against me shall prosper. Gradually these truths became real in my heart. I am so happy to say that even though my relationships are far from perfect, I have not stonewalled my sister or a significant other since. I am now so hopeful for the days to come, that God will continue to shape me and mold me, and I am so in awe of what God can do.

In this experience, I realized that living the holy life consists of repentance, community, and truth from God's word. And now I want to ask you—is there a sin in your life that you have come into agreement with the Enemy as part of who you are? Is there something

you feel is impossible to redeem? Instead of speaking death into these areas by saying—I am someone who stonewalls, I am an anxious person, I am a timid person, I am a lustful person—let's start instead submitting all of these things to our Father. There is nothing that is impossible for Him. No matter how deeply rooted and pervasive you think your sin is, it can be uprooted because God's love and his power goes so much deeper. Let's start going to our community for accountability and bring things hidden in darkness into the light. I hope we can be a church where our metric of holiness is not the number of hours we do Christian things, but instead how we confess vulnerably in our communities and lay our sins at the foot of the cross. Let's receive each other with the grace and love that we have received. Let's put God's truths above even our own thoughts and feelings. Let's not admit defeat but know that when we pursue God's holiness we also experience the true freedom that He gives us, for we did not receive the spirit of bondage but the spirit of adoption as His children.

And now I want to end with another verse to encourage you as we send you off this morning:

“...let us purify ourselves from everything that contaminates body and spirit, perfecting holiness out of reverence for God.” 2 Corinthians 7:1